

BESSIE COLEMAN



AFRICAN-AMERICAN PILOT Bessie Coleman (1892–1926) grew up in the Texas cotton fields, before moving to Chicago in 1915 and training as a beautician. There she decided that she wanted to become a flier, but she was refused entry to flight-training schools because of prejudice against her color. Undeterred, Coleman went to France in 1920, inspired by her brothers' tales of women fliers and racial tolerance, returning to the US in 1921 with an international pilot's license.

"Queen Bess" went on to become one of the most famous barnstormers. The curiosity aroused by the novel spectacle of a black woman pilot undoubtedly helped her achieve celebrity status. Her ambition was to raise enough capital to open a flying school for African-Americans, but tragically she did not live to realize it. In 1926, while practicing for a show in Jacksonville, Florida, her plane went into a tailspin and she was thrown to her death.

**FIRST ATLANTIC CROSSING**

The US Navy Curtiss NC-4 flying boat made its first flight on April 30, 1919, just over a week before the start of its historic transatlantic crossing. This four-engine aircraft had a wingspan of 126ft (38.4m), was 68ft 3in (20.8m) long, and weighed over 16,000lb (7,000kg) when empty. Its maximum attainable speed was 91mph (146kph).

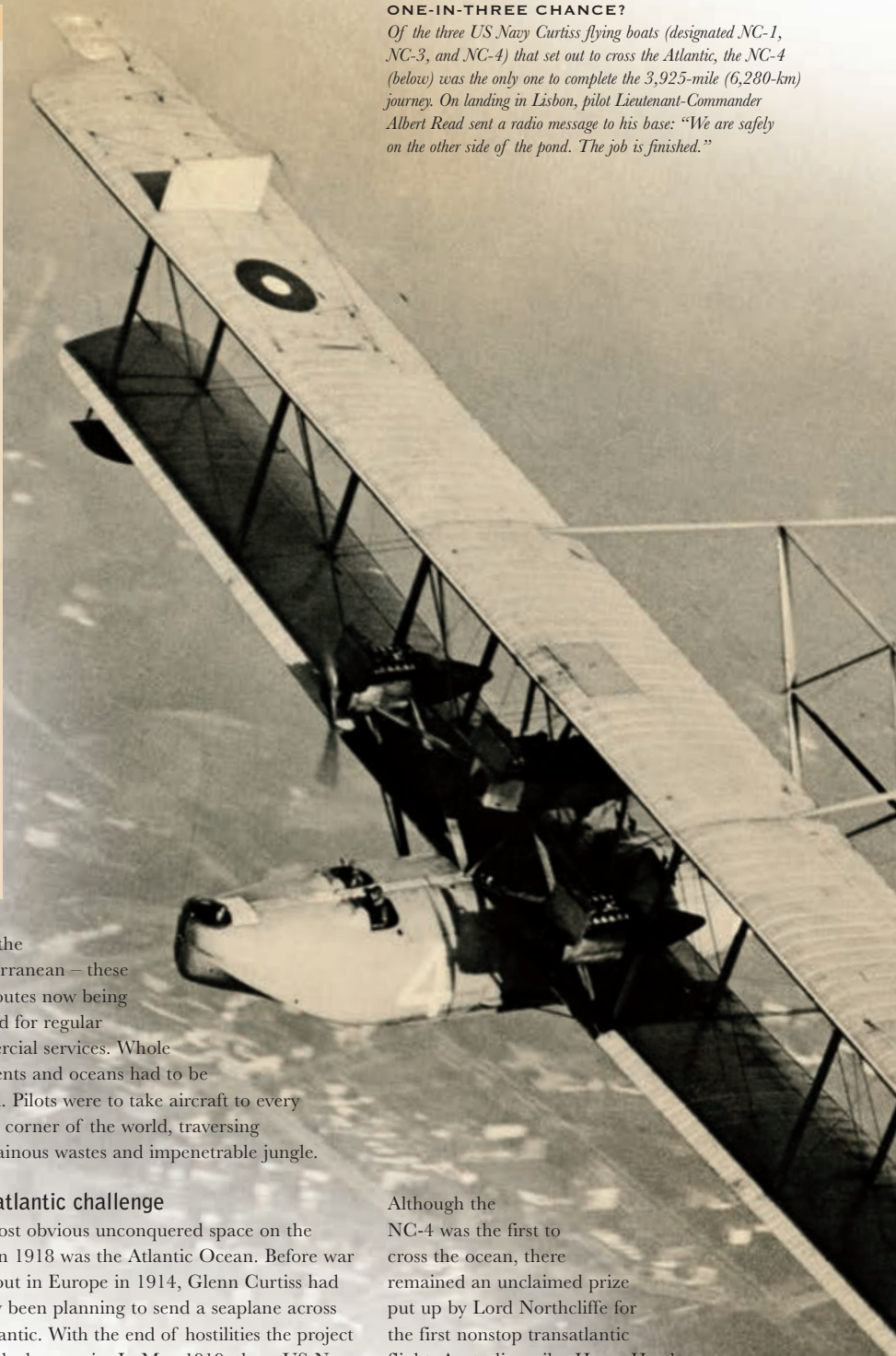
across the Mediterranean — these were routes now being targeted for regular commercial services. Whole continents and oceans had to be crossed. Pilots were to take aircraft to every remote corner of the world, traversing mountainous wastes and impenetrable jungle.

Transatlantic challenge

The most obvious unconquered space on the globe in 1918 was the Atlantic Ocean. Before war broke out in Europe in 1914, Glenn Curtiss had already been planning to send a seaplane across the Atlantic. With the end of hostilities the project was picked up again. In May 1919, three US Navy Curtiss flying boats set out from Newfoundland, Canada, for Lisbon, Portugal, via the Azores. Only one aircraft, the NC-4 captained by Lieutenant-Commander Albert C. Read, completed the journey, and that after many interruptions. The trip took 19 days, including 42 hours flying time.

ONE-IN-THREE CHANCE?

Of the three US Navy Curtiss flying boats (designated NC-1, NC-3, and NC-4) that set out to cross the Atlantic, the NC-4 (below) was the only one to complete the 3,925-mile (6,280-km) journey. On landing in Lisbon, pilot Lieutenant-Commander Albert Read sent a radio message to his base: "We are safely on the other side of the pond. The job is finished."



Although the NC-4 was the first to cross the ocean, there remained an unclaimed prize put up by Lord Northcliffe for the first nonstop transatlantic flight. Australian pilot Harry Hawker and navigator Kenneth Mackenzie-Grieve made an attempt in May 1919 that they were lucky to survive; after coming down in the ocean they were rescued by a passing steamer. The first successful nonstop Atlantic crossing was made the following month by two